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abandon it. *Kismet ki baat hai, varna Amitabh ko yeh mauka nahin milta. Zanjeer* went on to become a golden jubilee hit and heralded the rise of Amitabh Bachchan.

Salim Khan and I wrote 22 films, and 11 of them featured Bachchan. He'd never ever change a single word. We didn't have to explain the nuances of the language; he'd know. Writers tend to be a finicky lot, but in all the films we did, not even for one line did I feel that he had not enunciated and expressed the dialogue the way I had imagined. *Is mein koi shaq nahin hai ki jo performance* Zanjeer *aur* Deewaar *mein Amitabh Bachchan ne di hai, woh koi doosra nahin de sakta tha.* Let me not be too modest though. Nobody but Salim-Javed could have given him the kind of scripts he did in the '70s-'80s, and nobody could have given Salim-Javed the kind of performances he did.

To become Amitabh Bachchan, you need many qualities—monumental talent, complete discipline and focus, and perfect social relationships. Even at the age of 80, here is a man who still gives every shot as if it is the first shot of his life, and his career depends on it. He doesn't interfere in your work and gives you the space you need. It's why younger actors, who consider him God, realise on working with him that this God is benevolent. ■

'EXCEPTIONAL PERFORMANCES'

Shakti (1982)
Whenever you ask someone about their favourite Bachchan performance, the most common replies are *Zanjeer* (1973), *Deewaar* (1975), *Amar Akbar Anthony* (1977), *Trishul* (1978), and *Don* (1978). But there are some exceptional performances that have not been given their due. At the peak of his career, Bachchan played the angry but submissive and respectful son to Dilip Kumar's overimposing father in ***Shakti*** (above). At no stage Bachchan showed his arrogance. He could have taken the performance a few notches up to show his persona and none would have objected, but he didn't.

Mili (1975)
Jaya is obviously fabulous, but his work is unbelievable. When they talk of his angry young persona, I am surprised they never mention this film.

Screenwriter and lyricist Javed Akhtar, along with Salim Khan, played a key role in crafting Bachchan's angry young man image



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